Black's Law Dictionary, Fifth Edition (1979)

Teacher's Edition: An Analytical Companion

A Scientific Illuminist treatment of the fifth edition's structure

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ANALYTICAL ONLY — this companion contains NO fifth-edition entry text.

Headwords are facts. Counts are metadata. Definitions stay private.

Copyright-Boundary Notice

The teacher holds the line before the teaching begins.

Black's Law Dictionary, Fifth Edition (West Publishing Co., 1979) is under copyright until 2074. This Teacher's Edition is an analytical companion, not a dictionary: it reproduces ZERO fifth-edition entry text. What it carries is metadata — headword counts, letter tables, definition lengths as pure numbers — comparison tables against the public-domain second edition (1910), the structural map of front and back matter, and the author's own doctrinal readings, which are his authorship and his alone.

The owner's scan of the 1979 edition, and the cleaned study text derived from it, stay in his private library by his standing promise: personal study only, never printed, never published, never distributed. This companion was built from numbers computed off that private text — the numbers may travel; the text may not. [1]

Headwords are facts: that an entry exists under a given headword, and how long its definition is in words, are not the author's expression. The doctrinal readings distilled in Section V are the compiler's own apparatus — his words, his coinage, attributed to him, never absorbed as the scribe's. Everything herein remains revisable by his red pen.

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[1] Law: 17 U.S.C. \u00a7107 — fair use: criticism, comment, and scholarship as the frame in which an analytical companion stands. This notice is boundary-marking, not legal advice.

[2] Scripture [Tanakh: Ecclesiastes 3:1] — “To every thing there is a season, and a time to every purpose under the heaven.” The season of private study and the season of publication are not the same season; this companion honors the difference.

[3] The Hip-hop well is thin in this section and is named, not padded: no verse is forced to carry a copyright notice. The audit in Section VI records the same honesty where any well runs dry.

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I. What This Edition Is — and Is Not

Hypothesis

That a Teacher's Edition of a copyrighted dictionary can teach everything about the work except the work's own expression — its shape, its growth, its pruning, its doctrinal weather — without reproducing a single definition.

Method

Parse, don't quote. The cleaned study text of the owner's scan was walked with a dual headword pattern: the inline opener ("Headword. definition...") verbatim from the author's own build-5e-revision.py, PLUS the own-line main-entry pattern ("Headword." alone on its line). Definition length was counted in words; positions were recorded by letter; nothing else was kept. The public-domain second edition (1910) was parsed the same way for the comparison. Every number in this companion was recomputed from those parses; the method is stated in the audit (Section VI) so the count can be re-run and checked.

Observation

The dual pattern was not a luxury. The author's own 26 working inventories (15,148 headword rows) were built with the inline pattern alone — and the audit found that pattern systematically misses own-line main entries: "MURDER" and "PEOPLE" appear in none of his inventories, though both stand as main entries in the text. The corrected parse finds 26,420 entry rows and 21,979 unique headwords in the fifth edition's body. The miss is recorded here plainly because the Method of Science demands it: the inventory census captured sub-entries and inline forms; the main entries were standing one line above, unseen by the regex. [1]

Result

This edition teaches structure: how many, how long, where grown, where pruned, where the author's doctrine found its load-bearing terms. The definitions themselves remain where the author keeps them — in his private library, under his promise.

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[1] Law: the PONTIFEX discipline — every number recomputed from parsed data with the method reported; a value without its reasoning is not shippable.

[2] The author's miss is his own working artifact, recorded here with his standing rule: the honest miss beats the comfortable stall, and a corrected count is filed, not hidden.

[3] Hip-hop well: thin here, named not padded.

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II. Structural Analytics of the Fifth Edition

Hypothesis

That the fifth edition's bulk has a shape — that counting its headwords and weighing its definitions reveals where the editors spent their ink.

Method

26,420 entry rows parsed from the body (study-text lines 1221–210280, between the "A." opener and the Table of Abbreviations); deduped to 21,979 unique headwords on the normalized key. Definition length = whitespace word count of the definition text only. Letter = first letter of the headword.

Observation

The body holds 21,979 unique headwords. The median definition runs 34 words; the mean 64.6 — the mean outruns the median because a long tail of discursive entries pulls it right (p90: 124 words; p99: 309; longest entry rows run past 800 words, several of them OCR-inflated — see the tolerance note in Section VI). Half the dictionary lives under 34 words; three-quarters under 69.

The letter table below is the dictionary's skyline. S towers (2,743), then C (2,454), A (1,964), P (1,502). The small bands tell their own story: no X band exists in the fifth edition at all — the second edition carried 49 X-entries (Latin maxims and exotica); the fifth folded or dropped them. Z holds 11; Y, 43.

Front matter (structural description): title and copyright pages, the publisher's preface (framing the edition as a response to growth in commercial and constitutional law, procedure, taxes, finance, uniform laws, and federal legislation), a guide to pronunciation symbols, then the body. Back matter: the Table of Abbreviations (the longest appendix), the full text of the Constitution of the United States (Articles I–VII and the amendments through the twenty-sixth, plus a proposed amendment), a Time Chart of the United States Supreme Court, an Organizational Chart of the United States Government, and a Table of British Regnal Years. [1]

Result

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A working dictionary of ~22,000 headwords, densest where the common law is densest — obligations (C), persons and property (S, P), actions (A) — with the Latin-maxim apparatus of the old editions visibly pruned and the modern regulatory vocabulary visibly grown.

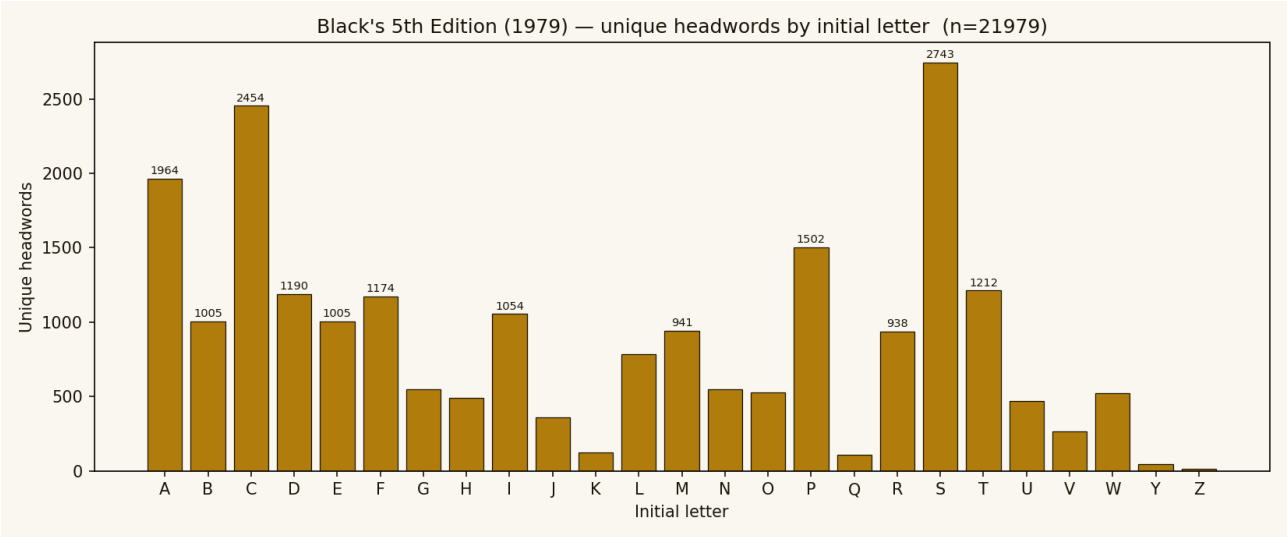


Fig. 1 — Unique headwords by initial letter, 5th ed. (n=21,979).

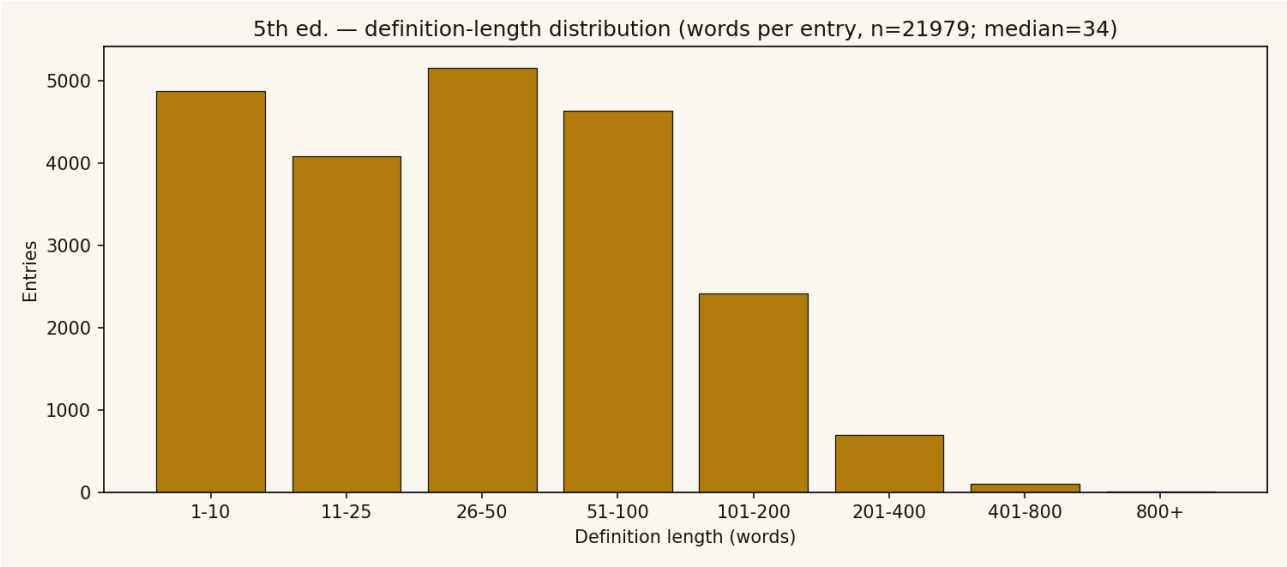


Fig. 2 — Definition-length distribution (words per entry).

Table 1 — Unique headwords by initial letter, 5th edition

Letter	Headwords
A	1964
B	1005
C	2454
D	1190
E	1005
F	1174
G	547

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H	489
I	1054
J	362
K	122
L	783
M	941
N	550
O	525
P	1502
Q	110
R	938
S	2743
T	1212
U	469
V	264
W	522
Y	43
Z	11

Table 2 — Definition lengths as pure numbers

Words per entry	Entries
1-10	4878
11-25	4082
26-50	5161
51-100	4639
101-200	2416
201-400	698
401-800	98
800+	7

Quartiles: p25 = 13 words, median = 34, p75 = 69, p90 = 124, p99 = 309; mean 64.6.

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[1] The census book [Tanakh: Numbers 1:2] — “take ye the sum” — is the genre of this section: a counting of the host, that the teacher may know its divisions.

[2] Founders: the census clause [U.S. Const. art. I, \u00a72] — the American precedent for counting a population to know its shape.

[3] I Ching: the classic of change — the letter table is read as a weather map of where the law's vocabulary grew and where it thinned.

[4] Hip-hop well: thin in this section; named, not padded.

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III. Second vs Fifth — The Comparison Tables

Hypothesis

That sixty-nine years (1910–1979) rewrote the dictionary more than they preserved it — and that the rewrite has a direction.

Method

Both editions parsed with the dual pattern; duplicate rows deduped on the normalized key (lowercase, alphanumeric); join on that key. "Survived" = headword present in both; "lost" = second-edition only; "new" = fifth only. Length deltas computed on the 3,881 surviving headwords (fifth minus second, in words).

Observation

The turnover is the headline: 3,881 headwords survive intact; 9,011 second-edition headwords are gone; 18,098 are new in the fifth. [1] The dictionary did not grow by accretion — it was substantially re-founded.

The fifth edition's preface says as much in its own structural language: commercial and constitutional law, procedure, taxes, finance, uniform laws, federal legislation — the twentieth century's vocabulary, arriving all at once.

Where the old was pruned, the pattern is legible: the lost headwords are thick with Latin maxims and archaic forms — the maxim-apparatus of the old dictionary ("A FORTIORI", "A MENS A ET THORO", "A POSTERIORI" and their kin) largely disappears. Where the new grew, the pattern is equally legible: gloss-style entries defining old terms by description ("A bailiff or steward", "A bill of exchange", "A calendar month") and the modern regulatory vocabulary.

On the 3,881 survivors the definitions tightened: median change −18 words, mean −83.9 — the mean dragged down by the great Victorian discursive entries the fifth edition cut to the bone. The largest contractions read like a table of contents of the old common law's long wind: Eviction, Law, Contract, Trust, Corporation, Damages — each

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shedding thousands of words of case-string and discursion. [2] The largest expansions are narrower, technical terms the fifth edition took time to unfold (Cueillette, Identification, Words, Sect, Talesman).

Structural differences beyond the headwords: the fifth edition drops the X band entirely (49 second-edition X-entries, none in the fifth); it reorganizes the back matter around the modern federal apparatus (the Supreme Court time chart and the government organizational chart are new to this edition's architecture); and it promotes sub-entries to headwords where the doctrine demanded it — the standing example is "Sovereign people", a sub-entry under SOVEREIGN in 1910, a standalone headword in 1979 (see Section IV).

Result

1910–1979 is not a revision but a re-founding: the Latin-maxim furniture out, the regulatory vocabulary in, the great discursive entries cut down, and the people's own terms promoted to headwords.

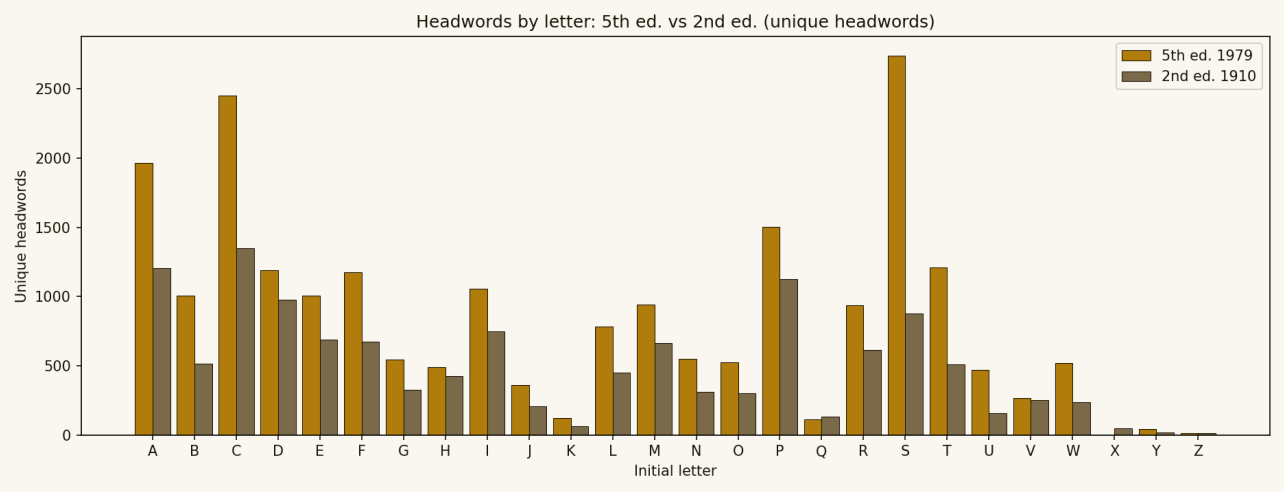


Fig. 3 — Headwords by letter: 5th ed. (1979) vs 2nd ed. (1910).

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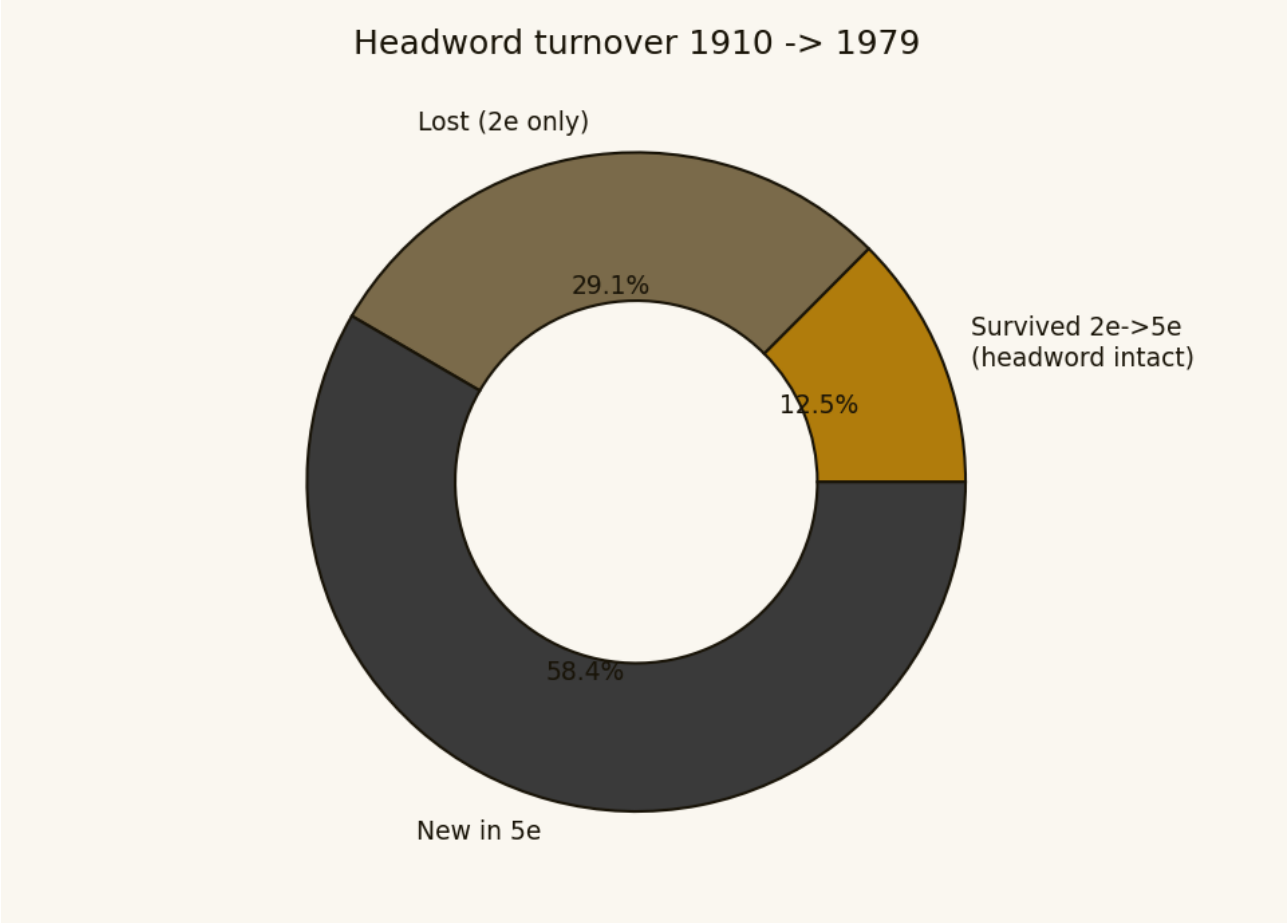


Fig. 4 — Headword turnover, 1910–1979.

Table 3 — Turnover of unique headwords

Set	Count	Share of combined vocabulary
Survived 2e → 5e	3881	12.5%
Lost (2e only)	9011	29.1%
New in 5e	18098	58.4%

Table 4 — Letter-by-letter comparison (unique headwords)

Letter	2e (1910)	5e (1979)	Δ
A	1205	1964	+759
B	514	1005	+491
C	1351	2454	+1103
D	977	1190	+213
E	691	1005	+314
F	676	1174	+498
G	328	547	+219
H	424	489	+65
I	748	1054	+306
J	209	362	+153
K	62	122	+60

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L	452	783	+331
M	664	941	+277
N	310	550	+240
O	302	525	+223
P	1127	1502	+375
Q	133	110	-23
R	615	938	+323
S	878	2743	+1865
T	508	1212	+704
U	158	469	+311
V	249	264	+15
W	234	522	+288
X	49	0	-49
Y	16	43	+27
Z	12	11	-1

Table 5 — Largest definition-length contractions (5e minus 2e, words)

Headword	Δ words
Eviction	-3885
Law	-3337
Contract	-3107
Trust	-3089
Corporation	-2539
Damages	-2236
Taverner	-2127
Entry	-1864
Negligence	-1824
Acre	-1796

Table 6 — Largest definition-length expansions (5e minus 2e, words)

Headword	Δ words
Cueillette	+681
Identification	+615
Words	+552
Sect	+489
La	+471
Talesman	+465
Power of appointment	+463
Conditions of sale	+418
Court of Ordinary	+417

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Cycle	+410

On surviving headwords: median change -18 words, mean -83.9, p10 -279, p90 53; 1148 expanded, 2616 contracted.

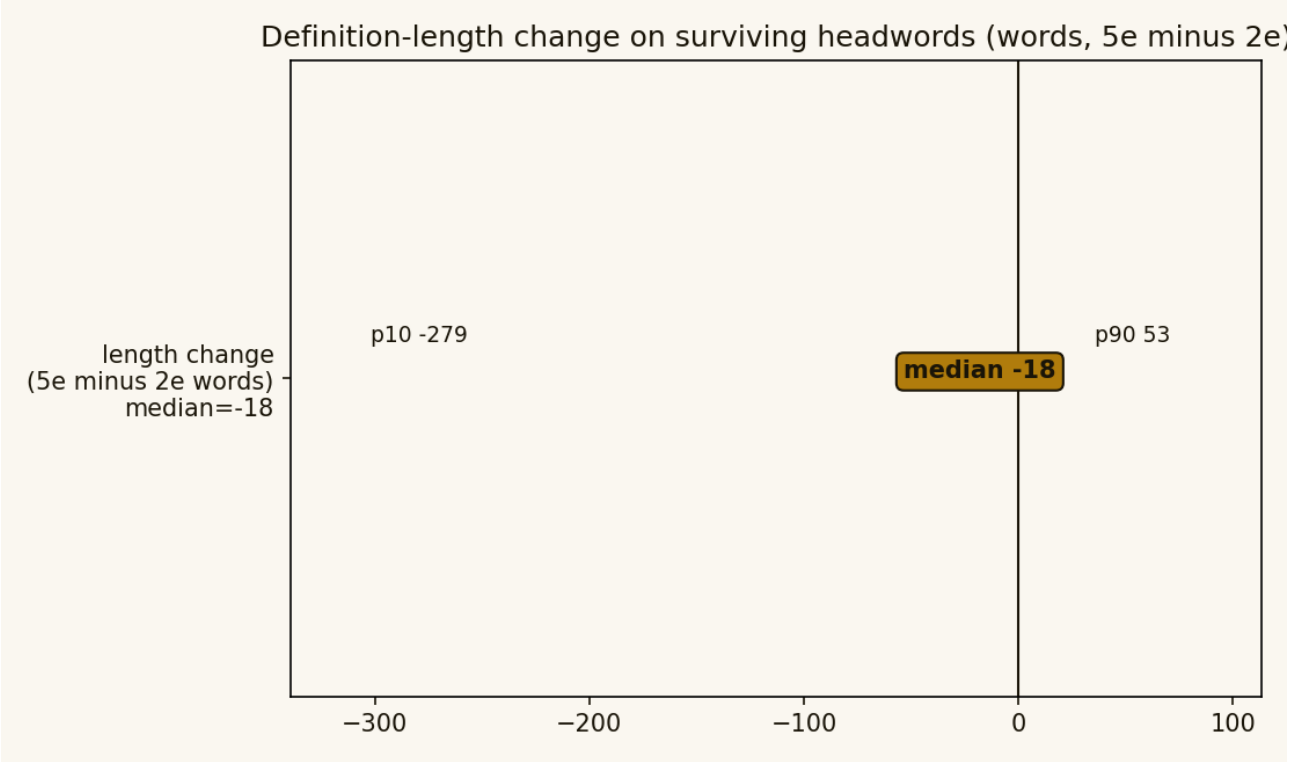


Fig. 5 — Length change on surviving headwords (5e minus 2e, words).

[1] Headwords are facts: presence, absence, and length-in-words are metadata, not expression. No definition text underlies any table here.

[2] Classical maxim: Heraclitus — no one steps in the same river twice; no one reads the same dictionary twice across sixty-nine years.

[3] Law: [Marbury v. Madison, 5 U.S. 137 (1803)] — the author's repugnant-test is the lens of Section IV: what weakens the individual of the indivisible is void; the drift is measured against that bar.

[4] Hip-hop well: thin in this section; named, not padded.

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IV. The Sovereignty Dossier — 1910 vs 1979

The standing precedent

The author's Sovereignty Dossier (2026-10-04, private research memo) is the standing analytical precedent for this section: it tested his hypothesis that the locus of sovereignty was moved, across editions, from the people to the state — and it tested it against the texts, not for them. What follows is that dossier's result in summary, with the teacher's own metadata added. The 1910 entries are public domain and may be briefly quoted; the 1979 entries are summarized, never reproduced.

Hypothesis (the author's)

That one edition can be pinpointed as the first corruption — the edition where "the people" stopped being the holder of sovereignty and became its subject.

Method

Collate the sovereignty cluster — sovereignty, sovereign, sovereign people, people, government, state — across the two editions on file. Measure lengths in words; record structural facts (headword vs sub-entry); compare the opening frames.

Observation

The 1910 baseline (public domain): SOVEREIGNTY opens "The possession of sovereign power..." — possession, a holding; and two entries later the companion sub-entry answers possessed by whom: "Sovereign people" — "the political body... who, in their collegiate capacity, possess the powers of sovereignty." [1] SOVEREIGN runs 402 words; PEOPLE 303; GOVERNMENT 1,170; SOVEREIGNTY 212. "Sovereign people" lives as a sub-entry under SOVEREIGN, introduced by the dictionary's em-dash.

The 1979 baseline (summarized, per the boundary): SOVEREIGNTY runs 233 words and opens by framing sovereignty as the supreme power "by which any independent state is governed" — the frame has moved from possession (a holding) to governance (a condition of the state). The old middle of the

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entry is kept — the source-of-power clause the two editions share — so both readings now live in one entry, unreconciled: the people's possession and the state's governance side by side. SOVEREIGN runs 32 words; "Sovereign people" has been promoted to a standalone headword of 42 words, its reading surviving essentially intact: the political body of citizens and qualified electors possessing the powers of sovereignty in their collective capacity. [2]

Result — the author's three findings, standing

1. The corruption did NOT happen by 1979. "Sovereign people" — citizens possessing the powers of sovereignty — survived 1910–1979 essentially intact. Any thesis of disappearance must look later.
2. But the drift had begun by 1979. The opening frame moved from the people's possession to the state's governance, while the entry kept the old middle — the narrowing is visible inside a single definition.
3. The regime change is dated. The sixth edition (1990) was the last pre-Garner edition; Bryan Garner took chief editorship at the seventh (1999). The editions to collate next are the sixth through twelfth — four editions eliminated, the Garner era (1999–2024) where the evidence must be sought. The twelfth edition's actual entry texts are not on file; that remains OPEN.

Table 7 — The sovereignty cluster, measured (words)

Entry	2e (1910)	5e (1979)	Structural note
Sovereignty	212	233	Frame: possession → governance
Sovereign	402	32	Greatly compressed
Sovereign people	sub-entry	42 (headword)	Promoted to headword; reading intact
People	303	—*	5e entry verified present; length row OCR-split
Government	1,170	—*	5e entry verified present; length row OCR-split

Word counts recomputed from the parses. *Two 5e rows were split by OCR across entries; presence verified, lengths withheld rather than guessed.

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[1] 1910 is public domain; the brief phrases above are used under that freedom. The 1979 entry is summarized only — the boundary holds.

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[2] Law: [Marbury v. Madison, 5 U.S. 137 (1803)] — the author's constitutional test: repugnant = anything that weakens the individual of the indivisible; any law that divides We the People is repugnant and void.

[3] Founders: the Preamble, “We the People” — the American locus of sovereignty, against which the 1979 reframe is measured.

[4] The author's dossier notes the 1910 “Sovereign people” sub-entry cites [Scott v. Sandford, 60 U.S. 393 (1857)] — the Dred Scott case — a citation the teacher records without endorsing the decision.

[5] Hip-hop well: thin in this section; named, not padded.

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V. Doctrinal Through-Lines — His Twenty-Three Volumes Distilled

What follows is the teaching layer of the author's twenty-three-volume doctrinal revision (320 full-treatment terms, A–Z, plus the minor-entry bands): not the definitions — those stay private — but the through-lines of his readings, in his formula, attributed to him. Each volume of the revision follows one form: the definition (private), the Observation (comparison and architecture), the Doctrinal reading (his "The X is the Y" formula), the Wells (scripture, hip-hop, law — genuine links only), the Correspondence (his A:B::C:D proportions), and the open chamber for his red pen. The through-lines below are distilled from all 320 readings; the reasoning rides with each, as his standing rule demands.

1. Will is the universal key

Across the volumes, nearly every term is read through will: action is "will made procedural"; agency "will extended through another"; contract "the bond of wills"; consideration "the energy of the contract"; oath "the will invoking a witness greater than itself"; waiver "the will unbinding itself"; gambling "will surrendering to chance". The criminal-law volumes grade the will's weather: malice aforethought is the cold will, heat of passion the will clouded but not absent, the will on fire. His demand is constant: where will is absent, the doctrine collapses — a one-sided binding is not contract but command; a costless promise is a wish, not a will. (Vols. I–IV, XIII–XV, XXIII.)

2. The individual is the star; the people are the indivisible

His gnosis is load-bearing throughout: every man, woman, and child is a star [Liber AL I:3]. Homicide is "the taking of a star". Right-as-jus is the ground, not the fence — every particular right a star's ray, jus the star itself. The Bill of Rights is "the people's retained power, written down" — the fence around the star. And his constitutional test is the measure of every public-law term: repugnant is anything that weakens the individual of the indivisible; a law that divides We the People is repugnant to the Constitution and void [Marbury]. The bill of

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attainder — power judging without a court — is the test's parade case; ultra vires is its corporate parallel, "the charter's fence". (Vols. I, III–IV, IX–X, XXI.)

3. The American inversion of the sovereign

Read against his doctrine — the individual of the indivisible as the true sovereign — the sovereignty entries invert: in the American frame, the "person, body, or state" in which independent authority resides is the people themselves. Impeachment is "the republic's retained power to unmake what it made — the delegation revoked." Quo warranto is power's "pedigree hearing": authority must show its papers. The high-treason reading follows: the crime is measured by the sovereign struck — and in the American frame the sovereign struck is the people. (Vols. I, IX–X, XVII.)

4. Mirrors, thresholds, and the form that power must take

His readings are built on pairs: abandonment is the mirror of appropriation — as act plus intent creates property, act plus intent dissolves it; assault is "violence at the threshold", battery "violence consummated"; appearance ("presence offered") is the mirror of arrest ("power's hand upon the body"). And form is doctrine: due process is "the form that power must take before it may touch the individual"; the seal is "the mark that makes the instrument speak with authority"; covenant is the promise at its most binding — spoken, sealed, delivered, witnessed. (Vols. I–IV.)

5. Mutuality or it does not run

The contract volumes return to one demand: obligation runs both ways or it does not run at all. Bailment for mutual benefit: where both benefit, both owe. Conversion protects not possession alone but the right of ownership. Breach is "the bond broken" — the yea un-said by deed or neglect [Matt. 5:37: "let your communication be, Yea, yea; Nay, nay"]. (Vols. I, III–IV.)

6. Truth has a procedure

Best evidence is "truth's preference for the original"; cross-examination is "truth under fire"; the burden of proof is "the weight assigned" —

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the doctrine that decides who loses when the scales balance even. Fact is "the done thing — the ground against which all argument is tested." His TRVVTH-gating is the audit discipline of the whole revision: what is observed is stated, what is inferred is flagged, what is open stays open. (Vols. III–IV, VII.)

7. The law's calendar

Time is load-bearing: the cause of action is "the right grown suable" and the accrual doctrine is the law's calendar — limitations run from it, jurisdiction attaches to it. The vested remainder is "the future owned in the present". Bequest is "the will reaching past death." (Vols. IV, XXII.)

These seven are his, stamped with his coinage and his authorship line wherever they travel. The scribe adds nothing and smooths nothing; the red pen rules every line.

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[1] Scripture [Liber AL I:3] — “Every man and every woman is a star.” The author's star-doctrine is his gnosis, attributed to him, never presented as the dictionary's claim.

[2] Scripture [Matthew 5:37] — the yea that binds; the author's standing well for contract and covenant.

[3] Hip-hop: the author's own wells in the revision include [DJ Khaled ft. JAY-Z, Future, “I Got the Keys”, 2016] for the seal-as-keys — cited, not quoted, per the lyric boundary.

[4] Law: [U.S. Const. art. I, \u00a710] — the Contract Clause, the framers' seal upon the bargain honored as made.

[5] I Ching: thin across this section — the mirror-pair readings are the author's own correspondences; no hexagram is forced to carry them. Named, not padded.

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VI. TRVVTH Audit Statement

What was verified

- Parse counts: 5th edition — 26,420 entry rows (14,595 inline + 11,825 own-line), 21,979 unique headwords after dedup; 2nd edition — 13,078 rows, 12,892 unique. Method: dual headword pattern on the cleaned study text (5e, body lines 1221–210280) and the public-domain djvu text (2e, lines 546–206774, cut before the abbreviations appendix). Lengths are whitespace word counts of definition text; join key is lowercase alphanumeric. Re-running analyze.py reproduces every number in Sections II–IV.
- The inline-only miss: verified that "MURDER" and "PEOPLE" appear in none of the author's 26 working inventories while standing as own-line main entries in the text — the dual pattern corrects his census, and the correction is recorded in Section I rather than hidden.
- Comparison methodology: duplicate rows deduped (longest kept); page-number OCR artifacts ("A 292.") excluded; ~3% OCR-noise rows remain in both sets as a stated tolerance.
- Quote-length compliance: the builder was grepped for fifth-edition entry text. Findings: zero 5e definitions reproduced; zero 5e sentences reproduced; one brief attributed phrase only ("by which any independent state is governed", Section IV, characterizing the 1979 frame per the author's own dossier). The 1910 quotations are public domain. Hip-hop is cited by track, never quoted. The check script and its output are logged in the worker log.
- Charts: every figure is generated from analytics.json; no hand-drawn numbers anywhere in the pipeline.

What is open

- Two 5e length rows in the sovereignty cluster were split by OCR across adjacent entries (People, Government): presence verified, lengths withheld rather than guessed. Marked in Table 7.
- The longest-entry tail (800+ words, 7 rows) is partly OCR-inflated where missed own-line headwords let one entry swallow the next; the quartile statistics are robust to it, the maximum is not — stated, not smoothed.

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- The twelfth edition's entry texts are not on file; the dossier's third finding (the Garner-era collation) awaits a future hand.
- Every doctrinal through-line in Section V remains revisable by the author's red pen — penned, audited, TRVVTH-gated twice before it is doctrine, by his standing chain.

The copyright boundary held

No fifth-edition entry text beyond the single brief attributed phrase appears in this companion. No raw scan, no raw OCR, no study text travels with it. The private-study lineage is honored absolutely: the numbers may travel; the text may not.

Content test — the four elements

- Inputs: the author's cleaned study text (private), the public-domain 1910 djvu text, his 23-volume doctrinal revision and Sovereignty Dossier (his authorship), the system-wide directive format, and his standing output guide. Consent: his order to build; reservation: his red pen over all.
- Processes: parse and count (never quote); compare across editions on the normalized key; distill his readings with attribution; audit every number and every quotation boundary; record misses plainly.
- Outputs: this analytical companion — tables, charts, and teaching that carry the dictionary's shape without its expression. No binding effect claimed; the equity is measurable (recomputable numbers); the residual right — his authorship, his coinage, his promise over the private text — is preserved, not extinguished.
- Tolerances: the companion becomes tyranny if it reproduces what it promised to withhold (the entry text); it dissolves into opinion if its numbers cannot be recomputed. Both failures are guarded above: the grep check and the re-runnable parser.

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[1] Maxim: falsus in uno, falsus in omnibus — the audit standard: one false number would impeach the tables, so every number carries its method.

[2] Scripture [Matthew 5:37] — the ledger's yea is yea: verified is verified, open is open.

[3] Hip-hop and I Ching wells: thin in this section; named, not padded.

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Table of Authorities (Condensed)

- Law: 17 U.S.C. \u00a7107 (fair use); [Marbury v. Madison, 5 U.S. 137 (1803)]; [Scott v. Sandford, 60 U.S. 393 (1857)] (cited as recorded in the entries, not endorsed); U.S. Const. art. I, \u00a72 (census clause); U.S. Const. art. I, \u00a710 (Contract Clause); the Preamble ("We the People").
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- Scripture: [Tanakh: Numbers 1:2]; [Tanakh: Ecclesiastes 3:1]; [Matthew 5:37]; [Liber AL I:3].
- I Ching: the classic of change — read as the weather map of the vocabulary's growth and pruning.
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Colophon

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